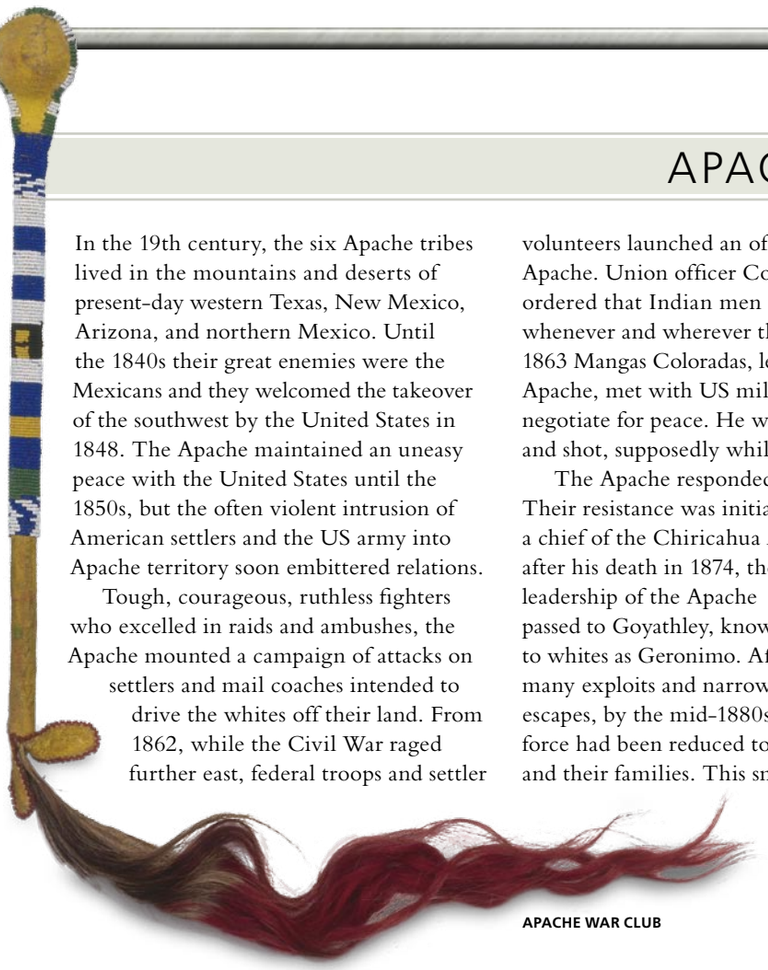
APACHE

In the 19th century, the six Apache tribes lived in the mountains and deserts of present-day western Texas, New Mexico, Arizona, and northern Mexico. Until the 1840s their great enemies were the Mexicans and they welcomed the takeover of the southwest by the United States in 1848. The Apache maintained an uneasy peace with the United States until the 1850s, but the often violent intrusion of American settlers and the US army into Apache territory soon embittered relations.

Tough, courageous, ruthless fighters who excelled in raids and ambushes, the Apache mounted a campaign of attacks on settlers and mail coaches intended to drive the whites off their land. From 1862, while the Civil War raged further east, federal troops and settler volunteers launched an offensive against the Apache. Union officer Colonel James Carleton ordered that Indian men were "to be slain whenever and wherever they can be found". In 1863 Mangas Coloradas, leader of the Bedonkohe Apache, met with US military commanders to negotiate for peace. He was arrested, tortured, and shot, supposedly while attempting to escape.

The Apache responded with guerrilla war. Their resistance was initially led by Cochise, a chief of the Chiricahua Apache; after his death in 1874, the leadership of the Apache passed to Goyathley, known to whites as Geronimo. After many exploits and narrow escapes, by the mid-1880s Geronimo's rebel force had been reduced to just 17 warriors and their families. This small band was pursued by 5,000 US troops, plus thousands of militia and Mexican volunteers. Geronimo surrendered in September 1886. He was held as a prisoner of war up to his death in 1909.



APACHE WAR CLUB



Decorated cap
Apache warriors wore buckskin caps that were decorated with feathers and with colourful beadwork in elaborate individual designs.

APACHE BUCKSKIN CAP

NEZ PERCÉ

The Nee Me Poo, named Nez Percé by French-Canadian trappers, lived by fishing and hunting on the Columbia Plateau in the northwest United States. They had generally good relations with the whites until the 1860s, when gold prospectors penetrated their lands. In 1863 the United States took the majority of the Nez Percé reservation to open up the area for mining. The leader of the Wallowa band, known to whites as Chief Joseph, organized peaceful resistance to the land seizure. In June 1877, however, clashes broke out between the US army and Nez Percé bands. Numbering less than a thousand people, including women and children, the Nez Percé knew that they could not stand and fight. Instead they conducted a fighting retreat across 2,000km (1,200 miles) of mountain and plateau towards the Canadian border, pursued by several thousand US troops and their Indian auxiliaries.

The Nez Percé repeatedly outfought and outmanoeuvred their enemies, winning the praise of General William Sherman for their "almost scientific skill" in warfare. But in October 1877 they were surrounded near the Bear Paw mountains in Montana, 65km (40 miles) short of the border. After a five-day siege in which many Nez Percé were killed, Chief Joseph surrendered, declaring: "My heart is sick and sad. From where the sun now stands I will fight no more forever." A few warriors slipped through the army lines and escaped to Canada. The rest of the survivors were exiled to disease-ridden reservations far from their ancestral lands.



Bow and quiver
The bow was the basic weapon of all Native American warriors. It was typically made of wood reinforced with sinew on the side facing away from the archer.



Nez Percé brave
A warrior poses with ceremonial headdress and lance. The Nez Percé were renowned for their skill in breeding horses, and kept their best mounts for warfare.